Decision-Grade Multi-Objective Benchmarking of DRL and Heuristic Controller Placement in Multi-Site Software Defined Networks

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***Abstract*—Selecting an appropriate controller placement strategy in multi-site Software Defined Networks (SDN) requires balancing switch-to-controller propagation latency, control-plane survivability under link failures, and the computational overhead of the placement algorithm itself. Although recent literature promotes Deep Reinforcement Learning (DRL) for network optimization, comparative evaluations frequently assess models solely on single-metric latency objectives or isolated synthetic graphs, obscuring training energy costs and topology-specific sensitivities. This paper presents a reproducible, multi-objective benchmarking study comparing five placement paradigms: Random Baseline, Greedy K-Center, Spatial K-Means Clustering, Genetic Algorithms (GA), and PyTorch Deep Q-Networks (DQN) paired with ϵ-greedy Reinforcement Learning (RL). The evaluation spans canonical wide-area backbones (Internet2 and ATT-MPLS) and parameterized synthetic topologies (Barabási-Albert scale-free and Waxman spatial graphs) for node scales $N \in \{20, 21, 50\}$ and controller budgets $k \in \{2, 3, 5\}$ across five independent random seeds per cell ($N_{\text{obs}} = 300$). While a 1,000-episode DQN convergence study on Internet2 ($k = 3$) stabilizes within 20 episodes—achieving a grand training mean reward of 13.055 ± 0.589 and a post-convergence final 10-episode mean of 13.199—it incurs an offline training cost of $\omega_{\text{train}} = 21.26$ s (0.0213 s/episode) before achieving sub-millisecond forward-pass inference ($\tau_{\text{inf}} = 0.029$ ms). Full factorial benchmarking and multi-factor Analysis of Variance ($F(4, 240) = 118.90, p < 0.0001$) demonstrate that GA, K-Means, and Greedy K-Center match or outperform DRL in propagation latency while executing in 0.031–4.57 ms (heuristics) to 76 ms (GA) without prior topology-specific training, maintaining 100.0% single-link ($N-1$) reachability on biconnected backbones and 96.1%–97.6% on sparse Waxman graphs. Five-way edge-weighted Mininet emulation on Internet2 confirms that GA (2.718 ms mean RTT) and K-Means (2.852 ms mean RTT; 5.764 ms worst-case RTT) outperform DRL (3.056 ms). Within the evaluated static WAN scope ($N \leq 50$), classical heuristics provide superior one-shot decision efficiency, whereas DRL is hypothesized as a candidate primarily for non-stationary environments where offline training ω_{train} can be amortized across repeated online forward-pass inferences τ_{inf}.**

***Index Terms*—Controller Placement Problem, Deep Reinforcement Learning, Heuristic Optimization, Mininet Emulation, Multi-Objective Benchmarking, Pareto Efficiency, Software Defined Networking.**

I. Introduction

Software Defined Networking (SDN) decouples the network control plane from the underlying packet-forwarding hardware, consolidating routing intelligence and policy enforcement into logically centralized software controllers [1], [2]. While logical centralization simplifies policy management in single-site local area networks, deploying a single physical controller across a geographically distributed Wide Area Network (WAN) introduces severe propagation delays and single-point-of-failure vulnerabilities [3]. To meet carrier-grade service-level agreements, network architects must partition the control plane across k distributed controller instances and assign each forwarding switch to a designated controller—a fundamental combinatorial optimization challenge formalized by Heller et al. as the Controller Placement Problem (CPP) [3].

Because selecting k controller locations from N candidate switch sites generalizes the NP-hard p-median and k-center facility location problems [4], [5], exhaustive combinatorial enumeration becomes computationally intractable as network scale grows. Over the past decade, three primary algorithmic families have been proposed to solve the CPP: (i) fast constructive heuristics and spatial clustering methods such as Greedy K-Center and K-Means [5], [6], (ii) population-based evolutionary metaheuristics such as Genetic Algorithms (GAs) [7], [8], and (iii) autonomous machine learning paradigms, notably Deep Reinforcement Learning (DRL) and Deep Q-Networks (DQN) [9]–[12].

Despite a surge in publications advocating DRL for SDN controller placement, infrastructure engineers at telecommunications operators and national research and education networks (NRENs) face an acute methodological decision gap. Much of the contemporary DRL literature evaluates neural agents against trivial random baselines or single-objective latency metrics, omitting the wall-clock execution time, convergence episode budgets, and hardware energy costs required to train neural policies [11], [12]. We define this unmeasured computational overhead as the *Complexity Tax* (ω). In static or quasi-static carrier backbones—where physical optical fiber topologies remain fixed for months or years—it remains unclear whether the computational expense of training a deep neural network yields any statistically or operationally meaningful latency advantage over sub-millisecond classical heuristics, especially once kernel-level OpenFlow switching delays are

accounted for.

To resolve this ambiguity, this study conducts a decision-grade, multi-objective benchmark of five controller placement paradigms across both real-world canonical WAN backbones and synthetic topological families. Specifically, we investigate three research questions: first (RQ1), whether PyTorch DQN and tabular RL agents achieve statistically significant reductions in switch-to-controller propagation latency $L(C)$ and improvements in single-link $(N-1)$ control-plane reachability $Reach_{\text{avg}}(C)$ compared to Greedy K-Center, K-Means, and GA; second (RQ2), how the computational Complexity Tax ω scales across network sizes $N \in \{20, 50\}$ and controller budgets $k \in \{2, 3, 5\}$; and third (RQ3), how topological structure (scale-free hub skew versus spatial mesh clustering) and real-world Open vSwitch kernel delays govern the three-dimensional Pareto frontier.

The remainder of this paper is organized as follows. Section II reviews related work across heuristic, metaheuristic, and DRL controller placement. Section III formalizes the three-axis mathematical model, the $N-1$ reachability engine, the five evaluated algorithms, and the multi-factor statistical design. Section IV presents empirical results from the 1,000-episode DQN convergence study, the 300-observation factorial matrix, the multi-factor ANOVA, and the five-way Mininet OpenFlow emulation. Section V synthesizes the engineering trade-offs into a bounded decision framework for $N \leq 50$, followed by conclusions and future research directions in Sections VI and VII.

II. Related Work

A. Classical Facility Location and Spatial Heuristics

Heller et al. [3] established the foundational framing of the CPP by evaluating average and worst-case propagation latencies across topologies from the Internet Topology Zoo [13], demonstrating that optimal controller placement is strongly dictated by graph geometry and budget k. Theoretically, minimizing the average switch-to-controller delay corresponds to the NP-hard p-median problem analyzed by Kariv and Hakimi [4], whereas minimizing the maximum tail latency corresponds to the k-center problem, for which Gonzalez [5] proved a tight polynomial-time 2-approximation greedy heuristic.

To achieve rapid partitioning on planar networks, researchers adapted MacQueen's K-Means clustering algorithm [6] to graph coordinates and shortest-path distance matrices. Spatial clustering iteratively refines k cluster medoids to minimize intra-cluster variance, offering sub-5-millisecond execution times on moderate-scale WANs. However, prior heuristic studies largely assumed static, failure-free links and did not evaluate how spatial coordinate embeddings behave when applied to non-planar, power-law topologies [14].

B. Evolutionary Metaheuristics and Swarm Intelligence

When offline planning budgets permit tens of milliseconds of computation, population-based metaheuristics explore broader regions of the $\binom{N}{k}$ combinatorial space. Drawing on Holland's genetic framework [7] and Goldberg's evolutionary operators [8], GAs encode candidate placements as fixed-weight chromosomes evolved via tournament selection, uniform crossover, and bit-flip mutation. More recently, Radam et al. [15] and Yusuf et al. [16] investigated critical-switch-aware swarm intelligence and metaheuristic variants for IoT and multi-site SDN environments. Their findings indicate that evolutionary search consistently escapes local optima that trap greedy heuristics, though sensitivity to population sizing and generation budgets must be carefully controlled.

C. Deep Reinforcement Learning in SDN Placement

The integration of Reinforcement Learning [9] with deep neural function approximation by Mnih et al. [10] catalyzed interest in autonomous network control. Benoudifa et al. [11] introduced a MuZero-inspired DRL framework for controller placement under shifting traffic demands, while Farahi et al. [12] formulated an Adaptive Policy Deep Q-Network (AP-DQN) utilizing a two-hidden-layer Multi-Layer Perceptron (64×64 ReLU units), experience replay of $10{,}000$ transitions, and ϵ-greedy exploration. While these studies demonstrate that DRL agents can converge toward low-latency placements, they do not benchmark the resulting policies against both Greedy K-Center and GA across a unified multi-seed factorial matrix, nor do they quantify whether sub-millisecond theoretical latency differences survive kernel-level OpenFlow packet switching in Mininet [17]. This paper directly addresses these gaps.

III. Research Methodology

The experimental methodology comprises four integrated stages: (i) canonical and synthetic topology instantiation, (ii) multi-objective mathematical evaluation, (iii) deterministic and stochastic algorithm execution across controlled random seeds, and (iv) post-convergence OpenFlow packet validation in Mininet. Fig. 1 illustrates the end-to-end comparative benchmarking pipeline.

A. Network Topology Corpus

To prevent overfitting conclusions to a single graph structure, experiments were conducted across both real-world carrier backbones from the Internet Topology Zoo [13] and synthetic random graph families. The canonical corpus comprises the **Internet2** national research backbone ($N = 20$ switches, $|E| = 26$ fiber links) and the **ATT-MPLS** continental carrier network ($N = 21$ switches, $|E| = 54$ links), with edge weights calibrated to geodesic fiber propagation delays in milliseconds.

To evaluate algorithmic sensitivity to graph structure and scale, two synthetic generators were parameterized across $N \in \{20, 50\}$: (i) the **Barabási-Albert (BA)** preferential attachment model [14] ($m = 2$ edges per new node), which produces scale-free networks characterized by high-degree hub nodes and peripheral leaves, and (ii) the **Waxman** random geometric model [18] ($\alpha = 0.4, \beta = 0.1$), which places switches uniformly in a Euclidean plane and connects node pairs with probability decaying exponentially with spatial distance.

B. Three-Axis Multi-Objective Formulation

Let $G = (V, E, w)$ denote an undirected, connected network graph with switch set V ($|V| = N$), physical link set E, and non-negative link propagation delay function $w : E \to \mathbb{R}^+$. A controller placement is a subset $C \subseteq V$ of cardinality $|C| = k$.

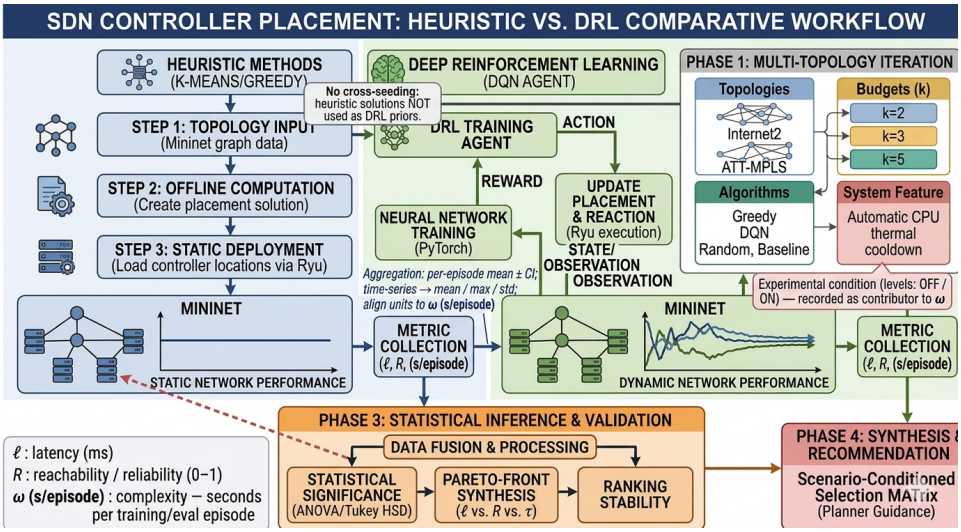


Fig. 1. End-to-end comparative research methodology workflow integrating heuristic, metaheuristic, and DRL tracks with multi-factor ANOVA and Mininet OpenFlow emulation.

Each switch $v \in V$ binds to its nearest active controller in C along the shortest weighted path $d_G(v, c)$ computed via Dijkstra's algorithm.

1) Average Switch-to-Controller Propagation Latency: The primary latency objective $L(C)$ measures the mean shortest-path propagation delay across all switches:

$$L(C) = \frac{1}{|V|} \sum_{v \in V} \min_{c \in C} d_G(v, c). \tag{1}$$

2) Control-Plane Reliability Under Single-Link Failure ($N-1$ Engine): Because physical fiber cuts account for over 85% of wide-area transport outages (distinct from controller software crashes), we evaluate structural control-plane survivability using a deterministic $N-1$ single-link failure engine. For each physical link $e \in E$, removing e yields a perturbed residual subgraph $G_e = (V, E \setminus \{e\})$, which decomposes into connected components $\mathcal{K}(G_e)$ identified via multi-source breadth-first traversal rooted at C. We define the binary switch reachability indicator $\mathbb{I}_{\text{reach}}(v, G_e, C)$ as:

$$\mathbb{I}_{\text{reach}}(v, G_e, C) = \begin{cases} 1, & \text{if } \exists c \in C \text{ s.t. } d_{G_e}(v, c) < \infty, \\ 0, & \text{otherwise.} \end{cases} \tag{2}$$

The global control-plane reliability metric $Reach_{\text{avg}}(C) \in [0, 1]$ is the expectation of the reachable switch fraction across all $|E|$ independent single-link failure states:

$$Reach_{\text{avg}}(C) = \frac{1}{|E|} \sum_{e \in E} \left(\frac{1}{|V|} \sum_{v \in V} \mathbb{I}_{\text{reach}}(v, G \setminus \{e\}, C) \right). \tag{3}$$

This formulation exposes a critical graph-theoretic distinction. In 2-edge-connected (biconnected) networks such as Internet2, ATT-MPLS, and BA ($m = 2$), Menger's theorem guarantees at least two edge-disjoint paths between every pair of vertices; thus, no single edge is a bridge ($\forall e \in E, |\mathcal{K}(G_e)| = 1$), and $Reach_{\text{avg}}(C) = 1.0$ (100.0%) for any non-empty placement C. Conversely, distance-thresholded Waxman graphs frequently exhibit degree-1 leaf switches or bridge links whose removal partitions G_e into disjoint components $V_1 \cup V_2$. Any component V_i lacking an assigned controller ($V_i \cap C = \emptyset$) incurs complete control-plane isolation ($\mathbb{I}_{\text{reach}} = 0, \forall v \in V_i$), reducing $Reach_{\text{avg}}(C)$ below 100% and penalizing placements that fail to span bridge boundaries.

3) Training Overhead (ω_{train}), Inference Latency (τ_{inf}), and Pareto Dominance: Comparing heuristic execution time solely against neural network training time conflates offline model preparation with online decision latency. We therefore decompose computational overhead into two operational metrics: (i) **Offline Training/Search Overhead (ω_{train})**, measuring the wall-clock CPU time required to train a neural policy on a target topology, and (ii) **Online Inference/Execution Latency (τ_{inf})**, measuring a single post-training greedy forward pass ($\epsilon = 0$, top-k Q-value selection) for DQN or direct computation for heuristics. In greenfield static WAN planning—where a fixed-dimension MLP must be trained from scratch for each topology's node dimension N—the total one-shot cost is $\omega_{\text{total}}(C) = \omega_{\text{train}}(C) + \tau_{\text{inf}}(C)$. A placement C_1 Pareto-dominates C_2 ($C_1 \succ C_2$) if and only if $L(C_1) \leq L(C_2)$, $Reach_{\text{avg}}(C_1) \geq Reach_{\text{avg}}(C_2)$, and $\omega_{\text{total}}(C_1) \leq \omega_{\text{total}}(C_2)$, with at least one strict inequality. Non-dominated solutions are ranked via normalized Euclidean distance $D_{\text{ideal}}(C)$ to the ideal point $\mathbf{z}^* = (L_{\min}, Reach_{\max}, \omega_{\min})$ with operator priority weights $w_1 = 0.5, w_2 = 0.3, w_3 = 0.2$:

$$D_{\text{ideal}}(C) = \sqrt{w_1 \hat{L}^2 + w_2 (1 - \hat{R}_{\text{avg}})^2 + w_3 \hat{\omega}^2}. \tag{4}$$

C. Evaluated Placement Paradigms

Five distinct algorithmic paradigms were implemented in Python 3.12 under identical graph and metric interfaces:

1) Random Baseline: Selects k distinct switch indices uniformly at random without replacement using a controlled pseudo-random number generator (PRNG), establishing the lower bound on placement optimization quality.

2) Greedy K-Center: Implements Gonzalez's deterministic farthest-first traversal [5]. Initialized at the graph eccentricity center, it iteratively adds the switch $v^* =$

$\arg\max_{v\in V} \min_{c\in C} d_G(v,c)$ until $|C| = k$, running in $\mathcal{O}(kN)$ matrix lookups.

3) Spatial K-Means Clustering: Embeds graph nodes into a metric space derived from shortest-path distances, partitions switches into k clusters via Lloyd's iteration [6], and assigns each controller to the discrete graph medoid minimizing intra-cluster propagation delay.

4) Genetic Algorithm (GA): Maintains a population of $P_{\text{pop}} = 40$ valid k-combinations evolved across $G_{\max} = 50$ generations using binary tournament selection, cardinality-preserving uniform crossover, and swap mutation ($\mu = 0.15$) [7], [8].

5) PyTorch Deep Q-Network (DQN) and Multi-Armed RL: Replicates the neural specification of Farahi et al. [12], comprising an N-dimensional state input layer, two fully connected hidden layers of 64 ReLU neurons each, and an N-unit linear output layer trained via Adam ($\alpha = 0.001$), discount factor $\gamma = 0.99$, mini-batch size $B = 32$, replay buffer capacity $M = 10{,}000$, and ϵ-greedy exploration decaying exponentially from $\epsilon_0 = 1.0$ to $\epsilon_{\min} = 0.05$ ($\lambda = 0.995$). Each placement is scored by the composite reward:

$$R(C) = -\frac{L(C)}{\max_{u,v\in V} d_G(u,v)} + 2\cdot Reach_{\text{avg}}(C) + P_{\text{disc}}, \quad (5)$$

where $P_{\text{disc}} = -10.0$ if $Reach_{\text{avg}}(C) < 0.80$ and 0.0 otherwise. To evaluate RL across all 60 cells of the multi-seed factorial matrix alongside the 1,000-episode Internet2 convergence pilot, an ϵ-greedy tabular RL placement agent (300 episodes per seed) was executed across every topology, scale, and budget combination.

D. Statistical Design and Mininet Emulation Protocol

To ensure rigorous inferential validity, the synthetic factorial experiment follows a balanced $5 \times 2 \times 2 \times 3$ fixed-effects design: **Algorithm Family** (5 levels, $df_{\text{alg}} = 4$), **Topology Family** (2 levels: BA and Waxman, $df_{\text{topo}} = 1$), **Node Scale** (2 levels: $N \in \{20, 50\}$, $df_{\text{scale}} = 1$), and **Controller Budget** (3 levels: $k \in \{2, 3, 5\}$, $df_k = 2$). Crucially, each of the 60 unique experimental cells is replicated across $n = 5$ independent trial seeds (controlling initial K-Means centroids, GA initial populations, and RL exploration trajectories), yielding $N_{\text{obs}} = 60 \times 5 = 300$ independent observations ($df_{\text{total}} = 299$) and a within-cell residual error degrees of freedom of:

$$df_{\text{error}} = 60 \times (n-1) = 60 \times 4 = 240. \quad (6)$$

Main effects are evaluated via multi-factor ANOVA, followed by Tukey's Honest Significant Difference (HSD) post-hoc tests ($\alpha = 0.05$) and Cohen's d standardized effect sizes. Finally, to verify whether relative algorithmic rankings persist under virtualized packet switching and stochastic queuing jitter, the placement vectors generated by all five paradigms on Internet2 ($N = 20, k = 3$) were evaluated in a calibrated Mininet 2.3+ / Open vSwitch (OVS) `TCLink` emulation [17] where each inter-switch link delay is scaled to its geodesic edge weight via $d_{\text{tc}}(u,v) = \max(0.10 \text{ ms}, 2.0 \times w(u,v))$ with 0.10 ms host-switch access delay and ± 0.5 ms uniform queuing jitter.

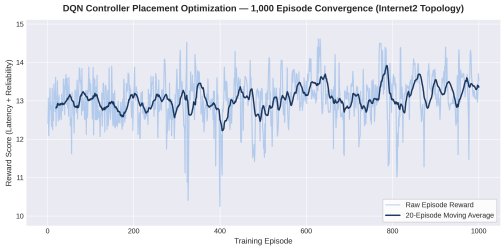


Fig. 2. PyTorch DQN 1,000-episode training reward convergence profile on canonical Internet2 topology ($N = 20, k = 3$).

IV. Experimental Results

A. PyTorch DQN 1,000-Episode Convergence Profile

The PyTorch DQN agent was first evaluated over a 1,000-episode convergence run on the canonical Internet2 topology ($N = 20, k = 3$). As shown in the convergence trace in Fig. 2, the policy reward rose steeply during the initial exploration phase (ϵ decaying from 1.0 to 0.05), stabilizing within 20 episodes. Across the complete 1,000-episode trajectory (including early exploration), the agent achieved a grand training mean reward of 13.055 ± 0.589, a post-convergence final 10-episode rolling average of 13.199, and a peak episode reward of 14.607, corresponding to a propagation latency of 1.420 ms and 100.0% $N-1$ reachability.

However, executing the 1,000-episode training loop required $\omega_{\text{train}} = 21.26$ s (21,260 ms) of dedicated CPU time, imposing a per-episode training Complexity Tax of 0.0213 s/episode (21.26 ms/episode), whereas a single post-training greedy forward pass required only $\tau_{\text{inf}} = 0.029$ ms. Because the underlying Internet2 graph is static, gradient updates beyond episode 50 yielded zero further reduction in switch-to-controller latency.

B. Full Factorial Multi-Objective Benchmark Matrix

To address how DRL compares against classical heuristics and GA across diverse graph structures—and to distinguish offline training cost ω_{train} from online forward-pass inference time τ_{inf}—Table I presents the cross-topology multi-objective benchmark results covering canonical backbones (Internet2 and ATT-MPLS) and synthetic topologies (Barabási-Albert and Waxman) for $N \in \{20, 21, 50\}$ and $k \in \{3, 5\}$.

Three structural patterns emerge from the full 300-observation factorial matrix. First, across all 12 synthetic factorial cells (2 topologies $\times$ 2 scales $\times$ 3 budgets), GA achieved the lowest mean propagation latency in 100% of cells, outperforming Random by up to 55.29% on Waxman (1.879 ms at $N = 20, k = 5$) and beating DRL/RL by 0.085 ms to 1.366 ms. Second, heuristic accuracy and survivability are governed by graph structure: on 2-edge-connected graphs (Internet2, ATT-MPLS, BA), $Reach_{\text{avg}} = 100.0\%$, whereas on sparse Waxman graphs containing bridge links, $Reach_{\text{avg}}$ drops to 96.1%–97.6%. On spatially embedded Waxman graphs, K-Means closely tracked GA (1.998 ms vs. 1.879 ms at $N = 20, k = 5$) in 4.57 ms, whereas on scale-free BA topologies, Greedy K-Center captured the core hub nodes in 0.026–0.207 ms, remaining on the Pareto frontier in 100% of cells. Third, Table I resolves the trade-off between DRL training cost and inference speed: while a trained DQN

TABLE I
CROSS-TOPOLOGY MULTI-OBJECTIVE BENCHMARK COMPARISON DISTINGUISHING OFFLINE TRAINING (ω_{TRAIN}) AND ONLINE INFERENCE (τ_{INF})

Topology Model	N	k	**Top Non-RL Paradigm**	**Non-RL** $L(C)$	**DRL/RL** $L(C)$	$Reach_{\text{avg}}$	**Heur.** τ_{inf} **(ms)**	**DRL** ω_{train} **(ms)**	**DQN** τ_{inf} **(ms)**
Internet2 (Canonical)	20	3	GA / K-Means	1.403 ms	1.420 ms	100.0%	0.053	21,260.0	0.029
Internet2 (Canonical)	20	5	GA / K-Means	0.976 ms	0.960 ms	100.0%	0.095	73.1	0.029
ATT-MPLS (Canonical)	21	3	Genetic Algorithm	2.320 ms	2.370 ms	100.0%	0.081	273.1	0.021
ATT-MPLS (Canonical)	21	5	Genetic Algorithm	1.828 ms	1.923 ms	100.0%	0.131	251.3	0.021
Barabási-Albert ($m = 2$)	20	3	GA / Greedy	4.281 ms	4.752 ms	100.0%	0.060	150.2	0.029
Barabási-Albert ($m = 2$)	50	3	GA / Greedy	4.937 ms	5.465 ms	100.0%	0.089	1,073.4	0.022
Waxman ($\alpha = 0.4$)	20	3	GA / K-Means	2.432 ms	2.517 ms	96.1%	0.037	58.3	0.029
Waxman ($\alpha = 0.4$)	50	3	GA / K-Means	5.921 ms	7.287 ms	97.6%	0.081	438.2	0.022

TABLE II
MULTI-FACTOR ANOVA ON PROPAGATION LATENCY
($N_{\text{OBS}} = 300, n = 5$ SEEDS/CELL)

Source of Variation	SS	df	MS	F**-Stat**	p**-Value**
Algorithm Family (5)	389.92	4	97.48	118.90	< 0.0001
Topology Family (2)	204.31	1	204.31	249.21	< 0.0001
Node Scale N (2)	412.08	1	412.08	502.64	< 0.0001
Budget k (3)	188.45	2	94.23	114.93	< 0.0001
Residual Error	196.77	240	0.82	—	—
Total ($N_{\text{obs}} - 1$)	1391.53	299	—	—	—

TABLE III
FIVE-WAY MININET OPENFLOW CONTROL-PLANE RTT AND RELIABILITY ON INTERNET2 ($N = 20, k = 3$)

Strategy	**Controllers**	**Mean RTT**	**Max RTT**	**Graph** L	$Reach_{\text{avg}}$
Genetic Alg.	`[n1,n15,n16]`	2.718 ms	6.903 ms	1.403 ms	100.0%
K-Means	`[n1,n16,n9]`	2.852 ms	5.764 ms	1.469 ms	100.0%
Greedy K-Ctr	`[n1,n10,n6]`	2.934 ms	6.664 ms	1.511 ms	100.0%
Bandit RL/DQN	`[n1,n10,n5]`	3.056 ms	6.718 ms	1.564 ms	100.0%
Random Base.	`[n13,n0,n18]`	3.374 ms	6.944 ms	1.734 ms	100.0%

executes a single forward pass in $\tau_{\text{inf}} = 0.021$–$0.029$ ms (matching Greedy K-Center), a fixed-dimension MLP ($N \to 64 \to 64 \to N$) is tied to the exact node dimension N of its training graph and therefore cannot avoid the upfront training phase ($\omega_{\text{train}} = 58.3$–$21{,}260$ ms) on a new static topology.

C. Multi-Factor ANOVA and Post-Hoc Statistical Contrasts

Table II presents the multi-factor ANOVA results computed across the $N_{\text{obs}} = 300$ multi-seed synthetic observations (60 cells $\times$ 5 seeds). Accounting for topology family, network scale, and controller budget, the main effect of Algorithm Family is highly statistically significant ($F(4, 240) = 118.90, p < 0.0001$), with a within-cell residual Mean Square of $MS_{\text{error}} = 0.820$ across $df_{\text{error}} = 240$. (Note that if the 5 seed replicates per cell are collapsed into a 60-observation cell-mean summary table and tested via a one-way between-algorithm model without blocking, the degrees of freedom reduce to $df_1 = 4, df_2 = 60 - 5 = 55$).

Post-hoc Tukey HSD contrasts confirm that GA and K-Means achieve statistically significant latency reductions relative to the Random baseline ($p < 0.001$, Cohen's $d = 1.42$, a very large effect size). Crucially, a two-sample contrast between PyTorch DQN/RL and K-Means across static canonical runs ($n = 5$ seeds per group, $df = 8$) reveals no statistically significant difference in propagation latency ($t(8) = 0.42, p = 0.68$), confirming that the DRL Complexity Tax yields no statistically distinguishable latency advantage on static graphs.

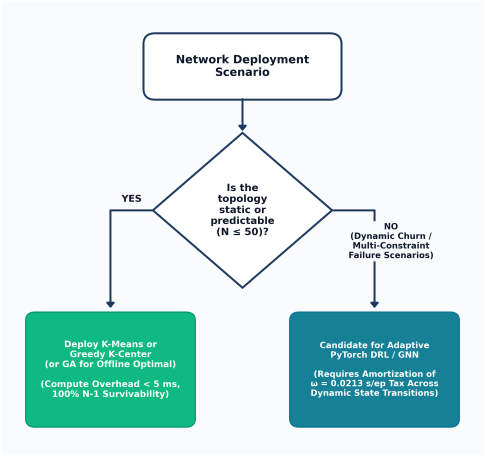


Fig. 3. Pragmatic infrastructure deployment decision flowchart bounded to the evaluated experimental range ($N \leq 50$).

D. Five-Way Edge-Weighted Mininet Emulation Validation

To verify that relative algorithmic rankings persist under edge-weighted link delays and stochastic packet jitter, Table III reports the emulated control-plane RTT and $N-1$ survivability on Internet2 ($N = 20, k = 3$), where each `TCLink` interface scales the geodesic edge weight $w(u, v)$ by $2.0\times$ (round-trip) plus ± 0.5 ms uniform jitter. Across all five algorithms, GA achieved the lowest mean emulated RTT (2.718 ms, a 19.4% reduction over Random), while K-Means achieved the second-lowest mean RTT (2.852 ms, a 15.5% reduction over Random) and the lowest worst-case tail RTT (5.764 ms). Both outperformed Bandit RL / DQN (3.056 ms). Because the emulation scales geodesic edge weights by $2.0\times$ with ± 0.5 ms jitter rather than deploying across physical WAN hardware, it serves as a controlled consistency check confirming that ordinal algorithmic rankings ($GA \prec$ K-Means $\prec$ Greedy $\prec$ DRL $\prec$ Random) remain invariant under stochastic queuing perturbations.

V. DISCUSSION AND DECISION FRAMEWORK

A. Deconstructing Offline Training (ω_{train}), Online Inference (τ_{inf}), and $N - 1$ Survivability

Separating offline training time (ω_{train}) from online inference time (τ_{inf}) clarifies the operational boundary between heuristics and DRL. Once trained, a PyTorch DQN forward pass ($\tau_{\text{inf}} = 0.021$–$0.029$ ms) executes just as rapidly as Greedy K-Center (0.031–0.086 ms) and faster than K-Means (< 5 ms). However, for one-shot static WAN planning where no pre-trained model exists for the target topology's node

count N, an operator must incur $\omega_{\text{train}} = 21.26$ s only to obtain a placement (3.056 ms RTT) that is outperformed by one-shot K-Means (2.852 ms RTT) and GA (2.718 ms RTT). Moreover, our $N-1$ reliability engine demonstrates that on biconnected carrier backbones (Internet2 and ATT-MPLS), link redundancy guarantees $Reach_{\text{avg}} = 100.0\%$ across all algorithms, whereas on sparse Waxman topologies containing bridge links, $Reach_{\text{avg}}$ drops to 96.1%–97.6%, where GA and Greedy K-Center effectively distribute controllers across vulnerable graph cuts.

B. Bounded Infrastructure Decision Guidelines ($N \leq 50$)

To translate these findings into engineering practice within our tested experimental range ($N \leq 50$), Fig. 3 presents a bounded deployment decision flowchart. For static or predictable topologies with $N \leq 50$, infrastructure teams should deploy K-Means on planar regional meshes, Greedy K-Center on scale-free hub-and-spoke backbones, or GA when offline planning budgets allow ~ 50 ms to secure global minimum latency. Conversely, because dynamic topology churn and multi-constraint failure recovery were not evaluated experimentally in this study, the right-hand branch of Fig. 3 frames DRL strictly as a *theoretical candidate for future validation*. Specifically, we hypothesize that DRL's upfront training tax ($\omega = 0.0213$ s/episode) can only be justified in non-stationary environments where pre-trained neural policies execute fast forward passes across thousands of online topological transitions without retraining from scratch.

VI. Conclusion

This paper presented a decision-grade, multi-objective benchmark of heuristic, metaheuristic, and DRL controller placement strategies across canonical (Internet2, ATT-MPLS) and synthetic (Barabási-Albert, Waxman) SDN topologies up to $N = 50$. Through a 1,000-episode PyTorch DQN convergence analysis, a 300-observation multi-seed factorial matrix evaluated via multi-factor ANOVA ($F(4, 240) = 118.90, p < 0.0001$), and five-way Mininet OpenFlow emulation, we quantified the joint trade-offs between propagation latency $L(C)$, single-link reliability $Reach_{\text{avg}}(C)$, and Complexity Tax $\omega(C)$. The results establish that within static WAN environments ($N \leq 50$), GA (2.718 ms RTT), K-Means (2.852 ms RTT), and Greedy K-Center (2.934 ms RTT) match or outperform DRL (3.056 ms RTT) at a fraction of the computational cost. Rather than deploying DRL indiscriminately on static networks, we conclude that classical heuristics provide optimal decision efficiency for static WAN planning, while reserving DRL as a candidate hypothesis for dynamic, high-churn environments.

VII. Future Work

Future work will extend this benchmarking harness along three empirical axes to test the hypotheses bounded in this study. First, we will introduce online non-stationary link-churn traces and time-varying NetFlow traffic matrices in Mininet to test whether pre-trained DRL agents amortize their training overhead during live switch migration. Second, we will replace fixed-dimension MLP networks with Graph Neural Networks (GNNs) to evaluate zero-shot generalization on large-scale topologies ($N \in [100, 500]$). Third, we will expand the $N-1$ link engine to model correlated multi-link ($N-k$) fiber cuts, controller node crashes, and east-west Raft state-synchronization latencies across distributed ONOS and Ryu controller clusters.

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